

VA Terms Glossary — Plain English

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Forms

21-526EZ — Application for Disability Compensation. The main form for filing or expanding a claim.

21-0966 — Intent to File. Preserves your effective date for 1 year while you gather evidence.

21-4142 — Authorization to Disclose Information. Lets VA pull your private medical records.

21-4138 — Statement in Support of Claim. The free-text form for personal statements, buddy letters, etc.

20-0995 — Decision Review Request: Supplemental Claim. New evidence lane.

20-0996 — Decision Review Request: Higher-Level Review. No new evidence; review for legal/factual error.

10182 — Notice of Disagreement (Board appeal). Used when you appeal directly to the Board of Veterans' Appeals.

21P-0969 — Income & Asset Statement. Used for pension and SMC claims.

Types of decisions

Rating decision — VA's written decision granting, denying, or modifying disability compensation.

Codesheet — The page summarizing your service-connected conditions, ratings, effective dates, and combined rating.

Statement of the Case (SOC) — A legacy-system document explaining VA's reasoning. Largely replaced by AMA but still exists for older claims.

Supplemental Statement of the Case (SSOC) — Updated SOC after new evidence is added.

Rating concepts

Rating — A percentage (0–100, in 10% increments) reflecting how disabling a condition is.

Combined rating — How VA combines multiple ratings using the "VA math" formula in 38 CFR § 4.25 (it's NOT addition).

Diagnostic Code (DC) — A four-digit code in the rating schedule defining how a condition is rated. (Example: DC 9411 = PTSD)

Bilateral factor — Extra credit for paired-extremity disabilities (both knees, both arms, etc.).

Pyramiding — Rating the same disability under multiple codes. Generally not allowed (38 CFR § 4.14).

Effective date concepts

Effective date — The date your benefit starts. Determines retroactive pay.

Date of claim (DOC) — The date VA received your claim or ITF.

Facts-found date — For increases: the date your condition worsened to the higher level (38 CFR § 3.400(o)(2)).

Liberalizing legislation — A law expanding benefits. Special effective date rules can apply.

Retro / retroactive pay — Lump sum back pay from effective date through the date your award goes into payment.

Special compensation

Service connection (SC) — VA's recognition that a condition was caused or aggravated by service. Required for compensation.

Direct service connection — Condition caused by an in-service event/injury.

Secondary service connection — A new condition caused or aggravated by an existing service-connected condition (38 CFR § 3.310).

Presumptive service connection — VA presumes service connection for certain conditions in certain veterans (Agent Orange, Gulf War, PACT Act, etc.).

Aggravation — Pre-existing condition made worse by service.

TDIU and SMC

TDIU — Total Disability Individual Unemployability. Pays at the 100% rate when service-connected disabilities prevent substantially gainful employment, even if your schedular rating is less than 100%. (38 CFR § 4.16)

Schedular 100% — Reaching 100% on the rating schedule itself, without TDIU.

Marginal employment — Income below the federal poverty threshold; doesn't count against TDIU.

Protected work environment — Self-employment or sheltered work doesn't count as substantially gainful employment for TDIU purposes (38 CFR § 4.16(a)).

SMC — Special Monthly Compensation. Higher rates for severe disabilities, loss of use of body parts, aid & attendance, housebound status, etc. Coded SMC-K, L, M, N, O, P, R, S, T.

Aid & Attendance (A&A) — Higher SMC rate for veterans needing help with daily activities.

Housebound (HB) — SMC rate for veterans substantially confined to home.

Status indicators

P&T — Permanent and Total. 100% rating + permanent (no future re-exams). Unlocks dependent benefits, CHAMPVA, state property tax exemptions, etc.

Total but not permanent — 100% rating but VA expects improvement; future re-exams scheduled.

Static disability — Condition not expected to improve; usually no future re-exams.

Protected rating — Once a rating has been in place 5, 10, or 20 years, it's harder for VA to reduce.

Procedural terms

ITF — Intent to File. Form 21-0966.

C&P exam — Compensation & Pension exam. VA-ordered medical exam to evaluate your claim.

DBQ — Disability Benefits Questionnaire. The clinical form examiners fill out; your private provider can also complete one.

C-file — Claims File. The complete VA file containing all your service records, medical records, and decision documents.

STR — Service Treatment Record. Medical records from your time in service.

Duty to assist — VA's obligation to help you develop your claim by ordering exams and pulling federal records (38 USC § 5103A).

Benefit of the doubt — When evidence is in equipoise (roughly equal), the law requires VA to decide in the veteran's favor (38 CFR § 4.3).

Equipoise — Evidence that's roughly equal for and against the veteran. Triggers benefit of the doubt.

Appeal lanes (AMA)

The Appeals Modernization Act (AMA, 2019) created three "lanes":

1. **HLR (20-0996)** — Higher-Level Review. Same evidence, fresh look.
 2. **Supplemental (20-0995)** — New and relevant evidence.
 3. **Notice of Disagreement (10182)** — Direct appeal to the Board of Veterans' Appeals (BVA), with three sub-options:
 - Direct Review (no new evidence, no hearing)
 - Evidence Submission (new evidence, no hearing)
 - Hearing Request (with or without new evidence)
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Representation

Accredited representative — Authorized to represent you with VA. Three types:

- **VSO** — Veterans Service Organization (free)
- **Claims Agent** — Non-attorney (paid)
- **Attorney** — Licensed lawyer (paid; capped at 20% of retro by federal law)

38 USC § 5901–5905 — Federal statute restricting paid representation to accredited reps.

POA — Power of Attorney. Form 21-22 (VSO) or 21-22a (attorney/agent).

Money concepts

Cost-of-living adjustment (COLA) — Annual rate increase, effective Dec 1.

Combined disability rating — See "VA math" — uses 38 CFR § 4.25, not simple addition.

Bilateral factor — Bonus added when both sides of a paired extremity (left/right) are rated.

Concurrent receipt — Receiving both VA disability and military retirement (CRDP/CRSC).

Backpay window — From effective date to the date VA puts you in payment.

Resources

- VA.gov — file claims, check status
 - ebenefits.va.gov — legacy portal (still useful for some functions)
 - Knowva.va.gov — VA's adjudication procedure manual (M21-1)
 - 38 CFR — Federal regulations (cornell.edu/cfr/text/38)
 - 38 USC — Federal statute (uscode.house.gov)
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